

Figure 3.11 *Shahr-i Zohak (fifth–thirteenth century), fortress ruins, interior. corridor. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

periods of Sasanian, Hephthalite, and Western Turkic dominance – that is, the sixth through tenth centuries CE – evidenced from Balkh through Bamiyan and Ghur, and likely extending into Sistan as well.[51]

With the enduring shift in routes of travel and commerce to foster Bamiyan's position as a regional entrepôt, the area continued to be something of a valuable territorial possession for local powers even after the Sasanians' and Western Turks' respective and gradual disintegrations. To be sure, the relentless 'Umayyad and 'Abbasid incursions into Afghanistan had disrupted political stability from the end of the seventh through eighth centuries, also causing a noticeable diminution in the volume of traffic through Bamiyan. Eventually, the Sistani Saffarids' and ultimately the Samanids' successes (i.e., further erosion of Turkic power) restored some calm, though the locale was no longer the great cosmopolitan center of the preceding two centuries. Nevertheless, Bamiyan and contiguous areas passed into the hands of the Samanids' *ghulam* general Sabuktigin